to join any bloc, giving India the option of seeking assistance from both the US and the Soviet Union while being able to speak against either on specific issues. India saw non-alignment as a way of keeping the cold war out of South Asia and of protecting itself against the perils of being drawn into clashes it sought to avoid. This would ensure a peaceful and stable environment for building the country, especially its economic and military capabilities.

Championing non-alignment helped India build ties with countries in Asia and Africa emerging from colonial rule, before whom India projected herself as a potential model and leader of former fellow colonies. Lacking in economic and military capability, India adopted the high moral ground in the hope of playing a greater role in world affairs and to punch above its weight.

India benefited from non-alignment but things did not always pan out as expected. While India remained non-aligned, Pakistan joined the Western camp. The cold war was never far from India's borders: communist China (initially aligned with the Soviet Union) shared India's frontier; Iran and Pakistan joined the US-led Central Treaty Organization (CENTO) and provided listening posts to the Central Intelligence Agency (CIA); the Soviets looked upon Afghanistan as a crucial neighbour even before sending in their forces there in 1979. American and Soviet navies both operated in the Indian Ocean, occasionally seeking the right to visit Indian ports.

While India was able to obtain some military and economic aid from both cold war blocs, it was never able to achieve the absolute autonomy in decision making it sought. It had to turn to the US after the war with China in 1962 and to the Soviet Union during the Bangladesh crisis of 1971. Domestic, regional and international circumstances circumscribed India's options, a lesson in the limits of a poor, developing country being able to